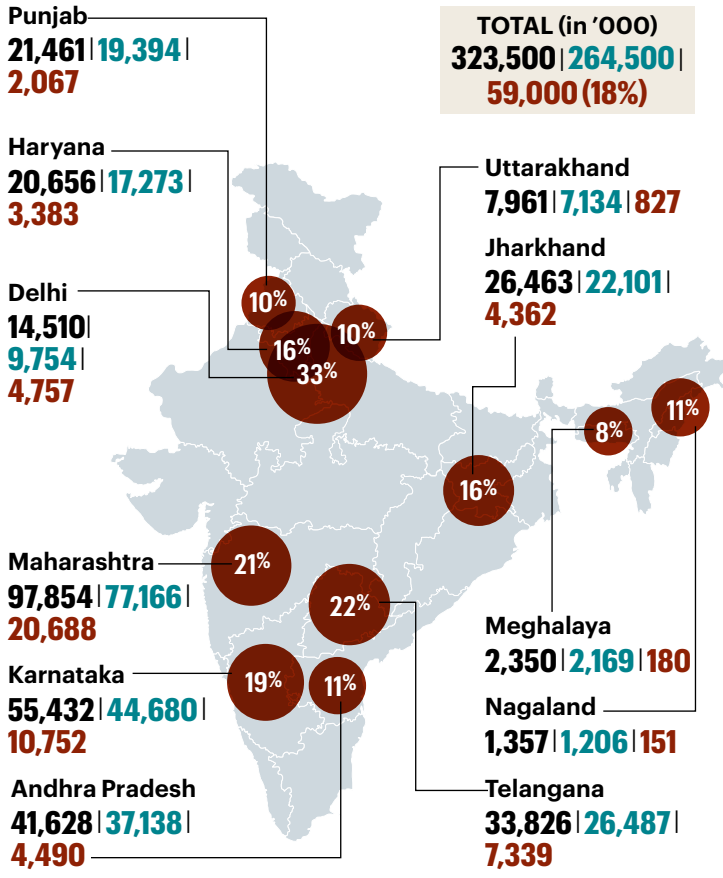
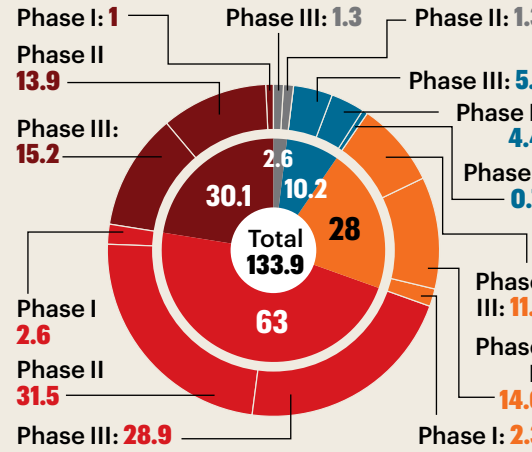
STATES WHERE ONLY A DRAFT ROLL IS AVAILABLE



Note: The 59 million figure is not the final deletion count. These are names absent from draft rolls in states/ UTs where claims, objections, hearings and restoration processes are still under way

133.9 MN OR 2.6 MN?

Of the 133.9 mn names left out of SIR draft rolls, ECI says 131.3 mn were classified as dead, absent, shifted or duplicate, leaving 2.6 mn out for issues such as documentation





"The ECI has made it clear that every decision relating to SIR was taken unanimously by the full commission"

—NITIN NABIN, *President, BJP*

Sandhu asked who had authorised the appeals "on behalf of ECI", recording that neither he nor Joshi had been informed. The apex court is now scheduled to hear, on October 5, petitions over unresolved voter appeals in the Bengal SIR, just a day before bypolls in the state.

The ECI defends the SIR on three grounds. The rolls had not been intensively revised for more than two decades and had accumulated dead, migrated and duplicate entries, an issue parties across the political spectrum had raised. ECI sources point to considerable disinformation on the number of people left out of the rolls. Of the 133.9 million individuals who do not figure in draft rolls, they say 131.3 million—or 98 per cent—fall into four categories: dead, absent, shifted or duplicate. That leaves some 2.6 million excluded for other reasons, such as documentation. The ECI also claims no name is deleted without notice and a hearing, and that the exercise has so far survived judicial scrutiny. Individual errors must be corrected, sources acknowledge, but they cannot by themselves establish that the entire system was designed to exclude legitimate voters. Accused of callousness over deletions and objections, the ECI met on September 26 and softened the process. Booth-level officers will ordinarily visit flagged voters and upload their documents; online hearings are preferred; adult family members may represent voters; help desks will assist vulnerable groups; and deadlines for filing claims have been extended in Delhi and Maharashtra.

Crisis 2: The Form 6 overreach

The sharpest legal dispute, and the one that attracts profiling charges, concerns Form 6. Prescribed by Rule 13 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, it allows a new voter to seek inclusion in an electoral roll. Under Section 28 of the 1950 Act, it can be amended only by the central government after consulting the ECI and notifying the change in the Official Gazette, after which the amendment must be laid before both Houses for 30 sitting days. That was how Form 6 was last amended, in 2022. By July 12 this year, however, the online Form 6 on ECINet carried a new section between Parts J and K asking whether the